

London Web Lab

The Web Lab is a set of five installations in the Science Museum at London. These "Labs" explore a particular feature in Chrome <http://dgit.in/MNRmLg>



3D Home Theatre System

Sony recently launches 3D Blu-ray Home Theatre System with High Definition Audio and Video

up more space on your hard disk (and slow your system just a little bit), but then, this is one thing that is not easy in OpenSUSE and is only present on Mint among all we tested (Mint is based on Ubuntu).

LINUX MINT 13 (MATE)

Linux Mint is based on Ubuntu and Mint 13 is based on Ubuntu 12.04. It even uses Ubuntu's repositories for much of the software you get here. However, Mint is the messy fellow in the Linux fraternity when it comes to "which edition to download". You have MATE and Cinnamon editions with and without Media codecs as well as KDE and XFCE to choose from. MATE is a Gnome-2 fork and is great for an average user, but does not have all the fancy effects and is good for lower-end machines (see its memory usage in table). Cinnamon is a Gnome-3 fork and is great as well. We used the MATE edition with media codecs and this is going to be the best thing for you if you want to get all popular media codecs, but do not have at least a basic broadband connection! Linux Mint 13 MATE edition comes with Gnome under the hood and does not offer the customisability offered by KDE. Also the DVD

does not contain any extra software you would love to have.

Much of Mint is Ubuntu except the UI. You get Synaptic Package Manager which offers better control over software install procedure and a menu that looks and behaves much like Windows' Start menu. Searching for apps in Mint is easier than it is in Ubuntu. The menu search even offers you to search for files with an additional mouse click. Altogether, Linux Mint is Ubuntu with a more intuitive interface. Mint is certainly the herb that would cure your resistance towards Linux caused by the irritant known as "bad multimedia support". Go for it if you want the perfect blend of simplicity, ease of use and power. Oh, and since it is based on Ubuntu, you can actually update from one version to another (with all the pros and cons of the process). With all good things from the most popular distro around and improving upon the bad parts of it, Linux Mint is deservedly the Editor's Pick!

FEDORA 17

Fedora is a test bed for RHEL and is a community project by RedHat. The installer is fine enough for an average user.

The release cycle is six months, repositories are always updated and it is



Fedora 17

actually good and fast enough. Sounds nice? Now for the bad part. You are not going to like the install process. The installer is more oriented towards enterprise setups. If you're using the default settings, you will first notice that auto detecting the Windows installation and offering a partition resize is not default. Next, if you did not customise the partition scheme, you will end up with LVM volumes and that is more enterprise oriented than it is home-user oriented for the simple reason that if you encounter problems, you will have a lot less help than with the regular partitions based setup.

It comes with software you would get on any other distro and probably the best thing is that the updates are smaller in size, thanks to "delta RPMs" in use (which is also the case with OpenSUSE, fortunately). Its good for users who are already experienced with Linux enough to solve basic problems if they get some. The recommended default DE is Gnome 3 and that is not friendly (remember that we are talking from the perspective of a seasoned Windows user who is not used to other environments).

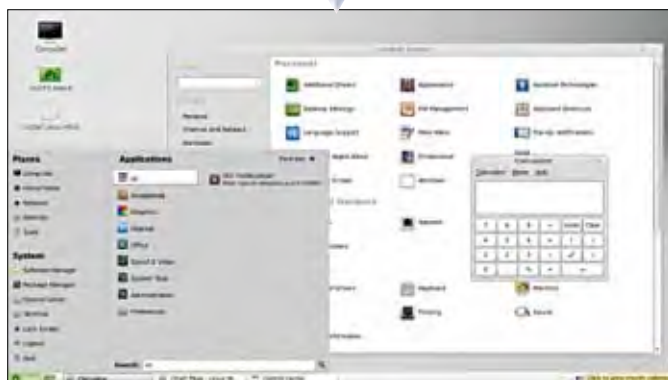
MAGEIA 2

Mageia is forked from Mandriva Linux and has been rising in the

popularity charts. For one thing – if an OS installation intimidates you, Mageia offers you a lot of advice and help while you install it alongside Windows. The experience is not too bad either. You have an easy-to-use but powerful control center, a good enough software installer and well organised controls for hardware and other settings. The bad side is – the software package manager, which does not offer you much control over the install process once it is started. It would go on downloading even if you closed the install window (and that's real bad). Gnome is the default environment. So you either get the DVD for it (like you should for Fedora) if you wanted KDE or be ready to experiment with a new UI (if you haven't experienced Gnome 3 till now). Most other features are the same as that of Fedora, except the fact that it will play MP3s for you (not any other media formats though). The good thing here is the helpful behaviour of its installer.

SLACKWARE 13.37

If you think that wild beasts with sharp teeth or red hot knives with sharp edges are great toys to play with, you will like this one. The installer is not GUI based to begin with and you have to format and-



Linux Mint 13 (MATE)